

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Jonah 1:1

Jonah son of Amittai was from Gath-hepher, a town located on the border of the tribal areas of Naphtali and Zebulun. He ministered to the northern kingdom of Israel during the reign of Jeroboam II (793–753 BC; see [2 Kgs 14:25](#)).

Jonah 1:1–2.10

Jonah initially rejected the Lord's commission to warn Nineveh of the judgment it had incurred because of its wickedness.

Jonah 1:2

By Jonah's day, Nineveh already had quite a long history (see [Gen 10:12](#)). It was a key city in the Assyrian Empire until its destruction in 612 BC (see [Nah 1–3](#)). Nineveh's ruins are located across the Tigris River from the modern city of Mosul, Iraq. • great city: See study note on 3:3.

Jonah 1:3

Jonah's attempt to get away from the Lord was futile. One cannot escape God ([Ps 139:7–10](#)) or disobey his will without consequence ([Deut 8:5](#)). Jonah's reluctance to go to Nineveh is understandable, however. Assyria was an enemy of Israel known for its violence ([Jon 3:8](#); see also [Nah 3:1–4](#)). Jonah did not want these non-Israelites to have the opportunity to repent and be saved ([Jon 4:2](#)). • Joppa was a key port city on the Mediterranean coast ([2 Chr 2:16](#); [Ezra 3:7](#)); it is now a suburb of modern Tel-Aviv. • Tarshish was possibly the port city of Tartessos in Spain, in which case Jonah was attempting to flee as far as imaginable in the opposite direction from Nineveh. Tarsus in Asia Minor is another possibility. Some think *Tarshish* is a general reference to the sea or to any destination accessible by sea.

Jonah 1:4

God's power over nature is a prominent theme throughout Jonah (see [Jon 1:4, 9, 13–16, 17](#); [2:3, 10](#); [4:6–7](#)).

Jonah 1:5–6

Jonah's ongoing sleep was perhaps induced by God to advance the crisis to a point where it was clear that the sailors' gods could not help ([1:6](#)).

Jonah 1:7–8

Use of lots was permitted by God for certain purposes (see [Lev 16:8](#); [Josh 18:6](#); [1 Chr 26:12–16](#); [Acts 1:26](#)); however, divination in general, as practiced in the wider ancient world, was displeasing to the Lord ([Deut 18:9–13](#)). • to see which of them had offended the gods: It was fairly common in the ancient Near East to assume that bad fortune was the result of a god's taking offense.

Jonah 1:9

a Hebrew: See also [Gen 41:12](#); [Exod 1:15](#); [2:11](#). • Jonah worshiped the Lord, who in contrast to the sailors' false gods made the sea and the land, and thus controlled them. Many gods were believed to have jurisdiction over specific realms and functions. The designation God of heaven likely conveyed the superiority of that deity over all others, as heaven is the highest realm. The Old Testament consistently proclaims that the Lord alone is the one true God (see, e.g., [Deut 6:4](#)), while at times adopting language that reflects his superiority to the false gods that occupied the imaginations of pagan peoples (see [Ps 95:3–5](#)).

Jonah 1:12

Throw me: Jonah's calmness in giving this direction is surprising. But he was willing to face death with equanimity rather than give the hated Assyrians a chance to repent.

Jonah 1:13–14

Instead, the sailors rowed even harder: It was now clear that Jonah was the one who had offended the Lord, but the sailors were apparently concerned that the Lord would be more offended if they killed one of his prophets.

Jonah 1:16

awestruck: God's display of power over the storm-tossed sea moved the sailors to worship. Although sacrifices and vows were aspects of Israelite worship (e.g., [Ps 116:17–18](#)), it is unlikely that the sailors were completely converted from the worship of false gods; they probably added Israel's god to their list. It is ironic that pagan sailors honored the Lord while the Lord's prophet, having dishonored him, apparently plunged to his death (cp. study note on Jon 2:8–9).

Jonah 1:17

Some critics consider it impossible that Jonah could be delivered from death in the belly of a great fish. In making this judgment, they oppose themselves to one of the book's main theological themes—that God is supremely sovereign over nature. If God exists, and he created and controls nature ([1:9, 16](#); see also [Gen 1:21](#)), a miraculous event of this magnitude is not unfathomable. The book presents the fish episode as a historical event. • No indication is given as to the species of the fish, nor is identifying a species crucial to validating the significance of the account. Granted God's creative power, the fish that swallowed Jonah might well have been specially formed and appointed by the Lord for this particular event. If God exists and can work miracles, Jonah's need for oxygen and protection from digestive processes poses no problem (cp. [Dan 3:14–27](#)). On the other hand, certain species are large enough to have served the purpose (e.g., the whale shark), and similar incidents have been recorded in modern times. • Jesus later referred to Jonah's stay in the belly of the fish for three days and three nights in predicting the duration of his time in the grave ([Matt 12:39–41](#)). • Arranged for is the first of four occurrences of the same Hebrew word in the book (see [Jon 4:6](#), [7](#), [8](#)). All four occurrences speak of God's effortless control over the forces of nature.

Jonah 2:1–9

Realizing that the Lord had graciously delivered him by sending the fish, Jonah composed this psalm-like prayer. Its careful structure, conforming to the pattern of an individual song of thanksgiving, suggests that it may have been composed after the event, as Jonah recalled his emotions and concerns.

Jonah 2:2

Jonah's psalm-prayer opens by recalling a previous prayer that was not so polished yet was all the more fervent—his cry for help while on the verge of drowning. • from the land of the dead (literally *from the belly of Sheol*): Sheol was thought to be the abode of the dead (see [Isa 14:15](#); [Ezek 31:15–17](#)). The belly metaphor for Sheol is found nowhere else in the Old Testament; it pictures Jonah's experience of being delivered from Sheol through the belly of a fish.

Jonah 2:4

On the brink of drowning, Jonah called out for help, for life, and for God's renewed presence. It is ironic that Jonah spoke of God as driving Jonah from his presence, for that was Jonah's own aim in fleeing to Tarshish ([1:3](#)). • I will look once more: Either Jonah was confident that he would be rescued and thus worship again in the Temple in Jerusalem, or he was calling to the Lord in his Temple from the sea (cp. [2:7](#)).

Jonah 2:6

Jonah's metaphors (roots of the mountains; imprisoned in the earth) reflect ancient concepts of the underworld, with the dead being deep within the earth (see also [2:2](#)). At one point Jonah felt hopelessly doomed to death's prison. • But: The transition is powerful. Jonah, though certain of his own death, was not beyond God's gracious reach. • the jaws of death (literally *the pit*): The Hebrew term normally denotes the habitat of the dead. Jonah's language again makes it clear that at this point he considered himself as good as dead.

Jonah 2:7

I remembered the Lord: In this context, Jonah's statement means "I turned my thoughts to the Lord in prayer." • earnest prayer . . . holy Temple: The Temple was God's special dwelling place in Israel's worship, even though God is present everywhere at all times ([Ps 139:7-10](#); [Jer 23:23-24](#)).

Jonah 2:8-9

The conclusion to Jonah's psalm-prayer bears similarity to [1:16](#): The sailors also responded to the Lord's power to save and acts of mercy with sacrifices and vows.

Jonah 3:1-2

The second part of the book opens as the first part did (see [1:1-2](#)).

Jonah 3:1-4.11

God again commands Jonah to preach to Nineveh. This time Jonah obeys, leading to an irony: The city repents, as Jonah had feared, and he is angry at God.

Jonah 3:3

a city so large that it took three days to see it all: God desired to save rather than destroy such a vast city, one teeming with human and natural resources ([4:11](#)). This desire on God's part was precisely what Jonah fought against (see [4:2](#), [10-11](#)). • The city's circumference was roughly three miles, and it would not have taken three days to walk around it. This description possibly indicates how long it took Jonah to spread his message throughout the city. It might also include the surrounding villages along with the city.

Jonah 3:4

Forty days from now Nineveh will be destroyed! Jonah's message apparently did not include a contingency clause—e.g., "But if you repent, God will not destroy you" (note the king's uncertainty in [3:9](#)). Jonah knew, however, of God's desire for

people to repent rather than be destroyed ([3:10](#); [4:2](#)).

Jonah 3:5-6

For the second time in this short book, pagans respond favorably to the Lord (cp. [1:16](#)). • In ancient Israel, fasting would often accompany prayer and repentance in times of distress (see [2 Sam 1:12](#); [Neh 1:4](#)). Wearing burlap and sitting on a heap of ashes would often accompany mourning and sorrowful repentance (see [Gen 37:34](#); [Job 16:15](#); [Lam 2:10](#)). The Assyrians apparently had similar customs. These activities allowed the participants to express their grief in a tangible way for all, including God, to see. • The repentance of the Ninevites was an indictment against the hard-hearted in Jesus' day ([Matt 12:41](#)).

Jonah 3:6

The king of Nineveh was either an unknown governor of the city or perhaps the king of Assyria, who might have used Nineveh as a regular seat of government (cp. [2 Kgs 19:9-13](#)).

Jonah 3:7-8

By extending the fast and the mourning rituals to animals, the king communicated that this dire emergency required all normal operations to cease so that everyone might pray earnestly and repent of their evil ways. The violence that had come to permeate their society topped the list.

Jonah 3:10

he changed his mind: Had the people of Nineveh not repented, God would have destroyed them ([3:4](#)). But God was ready to meet their repentance with mercy (see [4:2](#), [11](#)). In God's mind, the change did not reverse his original intention, because his disposition always included the possibility of mercy. Nor does this change in God's mind say anything about God's foreknowledge. Historically, the church has believed that God knows the future fully (see [Ps 139:4](#); [Isa 46:10](#); [Dan 2:28-29](#); [Matt 24:36](#)). Nothing in this account contradicts that belief.

Jonah 4:1

This change of plans (literally *It*): See study note on 3:10.

Jonah 4:1–7

The account takes an unexpected turn. Jonah, himself a recipient of God's mercy, complains about the mercy that the Lord has dispensed to the Assyrians. The prophet's insolence only magnifies God's grace (see [4:8–11](#) for God's response).

Jonah 4:2

Jonah expresses his motive in originally fleeing from the Lord ([1:3](#)): He knew that the Lord would not destroy the wicked Ninevites if they repented. • I knew: Jonah practically quotes [Exod 34:6–7](#), a passage set in the context of Israel's covenant relationship with the Lord. Even in the Old Testament, God was concerned to spread salvation to the nations (cp. [Matt 28:18–20](#)).

Jonah 4:3–5

Jonah's desire to die rather than embrace God's will (see also [4:8–9](#)), and his willingness to wait in hope that the city would be destroyed ([4:5](#)), are signs of his hard-heartedness and his hatred for the Assyrians.

Jonah 4:4

The Lord's reply is a rhetorical question. The implied answer is "No, of course not!" The object lesson that follows ([4:6–11](#)) reveals why Jonah ought not to be angry.

Jonah 4:6

The Lord is God's covenant name in relation to Israel (see, e.g., [Ps 72:18](#)). God did these things to show his covenant love toward Jonah and to those in Israel who had the same attitude. • arranged for: see study note on Jon 1:17.

Jonah 4:11

people living in spiritual darkness: God graciously sent the light of his prophetic word into a wicked city. Not all who encounter God's light respond favorably (cp. [John 3:19–21](#)), but God is eager to save those who receive his word in genuine repentance and faith. • The book closes abruptly, leaving the reader to ponder God's final question to Jonah. God would rather save than destroy. Those who have received his mercy must be glad for that same mercy to be shown to others, even to their enemies.